

Psalms 22

My God, My God, Why?

My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? why art thou so far from helping me, and from the words of my roaring?*
- 2 *O my God, I cry in the daytime, but thou hearest not; and in the night season, and am not silent.*
- 3 *But thou art holy, O thou that inhabitest the praises of Israel.*
- 4 *Our fathers trusted in thee: they trusted, and thou didst deliver them.*
- 5 *They cried unto thee, and were delivered: they trusted in thee, and were not confounded.*
- 6 *But I am a worm, and no man; a reproach of men, and despised of the people.*
- 7 *All they that see me laugh me to scorn: they shoot out the lip, they shake the head saying,*
- 8 *He trusted on the LORD that he would deliver him: let him deliver him, seeing he delighted in him.*
- 9 *But thou art he that took me out of the womb: thou didst make me hope when I was upon my mother's breasts.*
- 10 *I was cast upon thee from the womb: thou art my God from my mother's belly.*
- 11 *Be not far from me; for trouble is near; for there is none to help.*
- 12 *Many bulls have compassed me: strong bulls of Bashan have beset me round.*
- 13 *They gaped upon me with their mouths, as a ravening and a roaring lion.*
- 14 *I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint: my heart is like wax; it is melted in the midst of my bowels.*
- 15 *My strength is dried up like a potsherd; and my tongue cleaveth to my jaws; and thou hast brought me into the dust of death.*
- 16 *For dogs have compassed me: the assembly of the wicked have inclosed me: they pierced my hands and my feet.*
- 17 *I may tell all my bones: they look and stare upon me.*
- 18 *They part my garments among them, and cast lots upon my vesture.*
- 19 *But be not thou far from me, O LORD: O my strength, haste thee to help me.*
- 20 *Deliver my soul from the sword; my darling from the power of the dog.*
- 21 *Save me from the lion's mouth: for thou hast heard me from the horns of the unicorns.*
- 22 *I will declare thy name unto my brethren: in the midst of the congregation will I praise thee.*
- 23 *Ye that fear the LORD, praise him; all ye the seed of Jacob, glorify him; and fear him, all ye the seed of Israel.*
- 24 *For he hath not despised nor abhorred the affliction of the afflicted; neither hath he hid his face from him; but when he cried unto him, he heard.*
- 25 *My praise shall be of thee in the great congregation: I will pay my vows before them that fear him.*
- 26 *The meek shall eat and be satisfied: they shall praise the LORD that seek him: your heart shall live for ever.*
- 27 *All the ends of the world shall remember and turn unto the LORD: and all the kindreds of the nations shall worship before thee.*
- 28 *For the kingdom is the LORD'S: and he is the governor among the nations.*
- 29 *All they that be fat upon earth shall eat and worship: all they that go down to the dust shall bow before him: and none can keep alive his own soul.*
- 30 *A seed shall serve him; it shall be accounted to the Lord for a generation.*
- 31 *They shall come, and shall declare his righteousness unto a people that shall be born, that he hath done this.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 22 is David's most piercing lament, moving from an anguished cry of abandonment through vivid, almost prophetic suffering imagery to a triumphant vow of worldwide praise. The New Testament repeatedly identifies this psalm with Christ's crucifixion—His cry from the cross (Matt 27:46), the mockery, the pierced hands and feet, the parted garments, the gambled clothing (John 19:23–24)—making it one of the clearest messianic psalms in the Psalter. Henry and MacArthur-style commentary both read it as prophetic suffering that turns, astonishingly within one psalm, into confident praise reaching “all the ends of the world.”

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The opening cry of forsakenness—quoted by Jesus on the cross—paired with the ache of unanswered day-and-night prayer. Abandonment is named without denial or spin; this is the rawest possible language of felt divine absence.

Verse 3-5

Yet even mid-lament, faith recalls God’s holiness and enthronement amid Israel’s praises, and the historic pattern of fathers who trusted and were delivered, not put to shame. Memory of God’s past faithfulness steadies present anguish.

Verse 6-8

Self-description as “a worm, and no man,” reproached, despised, mocked by onlookers who shake their heads and taunt that God has not delivered him—language echoed almost verbatim by Christ’s mockers at the cross.

Verse 9-11

Appeal to a lifelong relationship with God, who took him from the womb and has been his God from birth—grounds for asking God not to be far off now that trouble is near and there is no other helper.

Verse 12-15

Intensifying suffering imagery: strong bulls and ravening lions encircle him; he is poured out like water; bones out of joint; heart melted like wax; strength dried up; tongue cleaved to jaws—a body-and-soul description of agony.

Verse 16-18

Enemies compass him “like dogs”; hands and feet are pierced; his bones can be counted as onlookers stare; they part his garments and cast lots for his clothing—details fulfilled with striking precision at the crucifixion.

Verse 19-21

A direct plea for help and haste—deliver my soul from the sword, my darling from the power of the dog, save me from the lion’s mouth and the horns of the unicorns. The prayer intensifies rather than resigns in the face of death.

Verse 22-24

A dramatic turn: “I will declare thy name unto my brethren,” calling the congregation to praise, because God has not despised nor abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, nor hidden His face, but has heard when he cried.

Verse 25-31

Praise expands outward: paid vows in the great congregation, the poor eating and being satisfied, all the ends of the world remembering and turning to the Lord, all kindreds worshiping, even future generations and a people not yet born declaring His righteousness—suffering transforms into worldwide, multigenerational praise.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Real, felt abandonment and unimaginable suffering can coexist with unwavering faith and ultimately erupt into worldwide, multigenerational praise—a pattern supremely fulfilled in Christ’s cross and resurrection.

Application for life today.

Let this psalm give you permission to voice the rawest cry of felt abandonment while still, like David, actively recalling God’s past faithfulness in the same breath. Read the suffering sections slowly as a window into what Christ endured on your behalf, deepening gratitude rather than rushing past the pain to the praise. And let the psalm’s ending stretch your vision: the suffering of one leads to praise across all nations and generations—ask how your own hard story might become part of someone else’s reason to worship.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where do you need to bring an honest “why hast thou forsaken me” cry to God rather than suppressing it?

2. How does seeing this psalm fulfilled in Christ’s crucifixion change the way you read His suffering—and your own?

3. What would it mean for your current pain to eventually become, like David’s, a testimony that leads others toward God?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).